

SOC Alert Triage & Phishing Investigation

Alert 8815 — Fake Amazon Phishing Email Targeting an Employee

Platform: TryHackMe SOC Simulator
Company (Simulated): The Try Daily
Date: June 22, 2026

1. Project Title & Goal

This case study documents the investigation of Alert 8815 — a medium-severity phishing alert raised by the SOC Simulator platform. I was working as a Tier 1 SOC Analyst for a simulated media company called The Try Daily, monitoring an active alert queue and triaging incoming security events.

Alert 8815 involved an inbound email sent to an employee that contained a suspicious external link. The investigation required me to determine whether the email was a genuine phishing attempt, whether the employee interacted with the malicious content, and whether any remediation or escalation was needed.

Objective

Work through a real phishing alert from start to finish — identify the threat, gather evidence from email and firewall logs in Splunk, validate indicators using threat intelligence, classify the alert correctly, and document all findings in a professional case report.

2. Tools Used

Tool / Source	Purpose
TryHackMe SOC Simulator	The simulation environment providing a live alert queue, documentation, SIEM access, and a virtual analyst workstation.
Splunk (SIEM)	Used to search email logs, firewall logs, and web traffic to trace the phishing email and confirm whether the recipient clicked the link.
TryDetectThis	Threat intelligence tool on the Analyst VM used to check URLs and domains for known malicious indicators.
Analyst VM	Virtual machine inside the simulator providing access to investigation tools including TryDetectThis.
Email Log Analysis	Reviewed inbound and outbound email logs to identify the phishing email, confirm delivery, and check for any related communications.
Firewall Log Analysis	Queried firewall logs to confirm whether the recipient's machine attempted to access the malicious URL and whether the connection was blocked or allowed.

3. What I Did

1. **Picked up Alert 8815 from the alert queue** — assigned myself the alert and reviewed the full details including sender, recipient, subject line, email content, and the embedded URL before doing anything else.
2. **Identified phishing indicators immediately** — the sender domain was amazon.biz (not amazon.com), the email used a shortened bit.ly URL to hide the destination, addressed the recipient as 'Dear Customer' instead of by name, and used a 48-hour deadline to create urgency.
3. **Searched Splunk for Hannah Harris's email activity** — queried h.harris@thetrydaily.thm to understand her recent email activity and establish a baseline before and after the phishing email arrived.
4. **Searched Splunk for Hannah's machine IP (10.20.2.17)** — checked firewall logs to see whether her machine had attempted to connect to any suspicious external URLs after receiving the email.
5. **Searched Splunk for the bit.ly URL directly** — confirmed that Hannah's machine (10.20.2.17) attempted to connect to http://bit.ly/3sHkX3da12340 at 17:41, just two minutes after the email arrived. The firewall blocked the connection.
6. **Ran both indicators through TryDetectThis** — checked amazon.biz (returned CLEAN) and the full bit.ly URL (returned MALICIOUS), confirming the link was a genuine threat.

7. **Made the classification decision** — True Positive. A real phishing email was received, the user clicked the malicious link, but the firewall blocked the connection before any damage occurred. No escalation required.
8. **Wrote and submitted the full case report** — documented all entities, timeline, IOCs, investigation steps, verdict, escalation reasoning, remediation actions, and attack indicators.

4. Investigation Summary

Step 1 — The Alert Queue

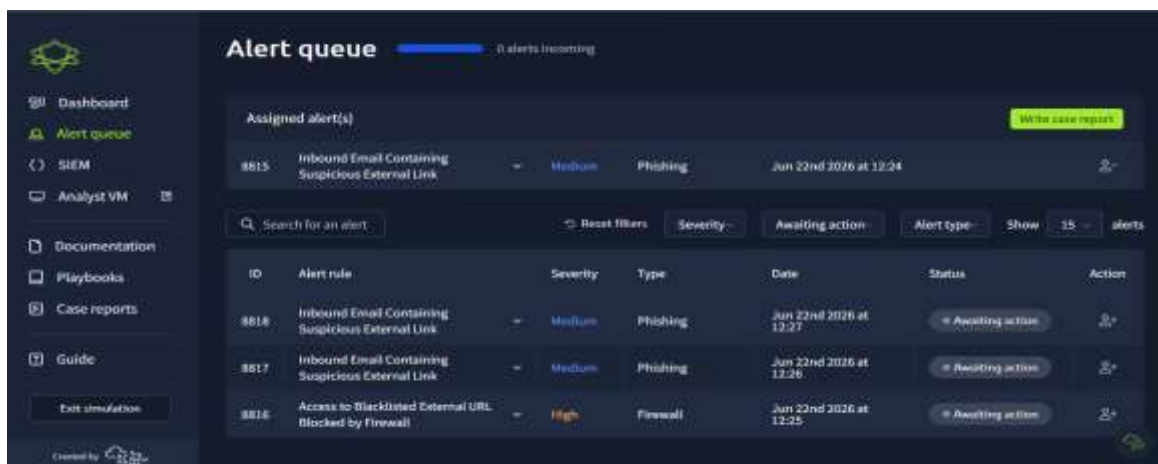


Figure 1 — Alert queue showing Alert 8815 assigned alongside other pending alerts including a High severity firewall alert

After closing Alert 8814, I returned to the alert queue and could see Alert 8815 waiting — another medium-severity phishing alert, this time dated June 22nd at 12:24. I also noticed Alert 8816 in the queue labelled 'Access to Blacklisted External URL Blocked by Firewall' with a High severity rating. That is something to come back to. First, I assigned myself Alert 8815 and read through the details.

Step 2 — Reading the Alert

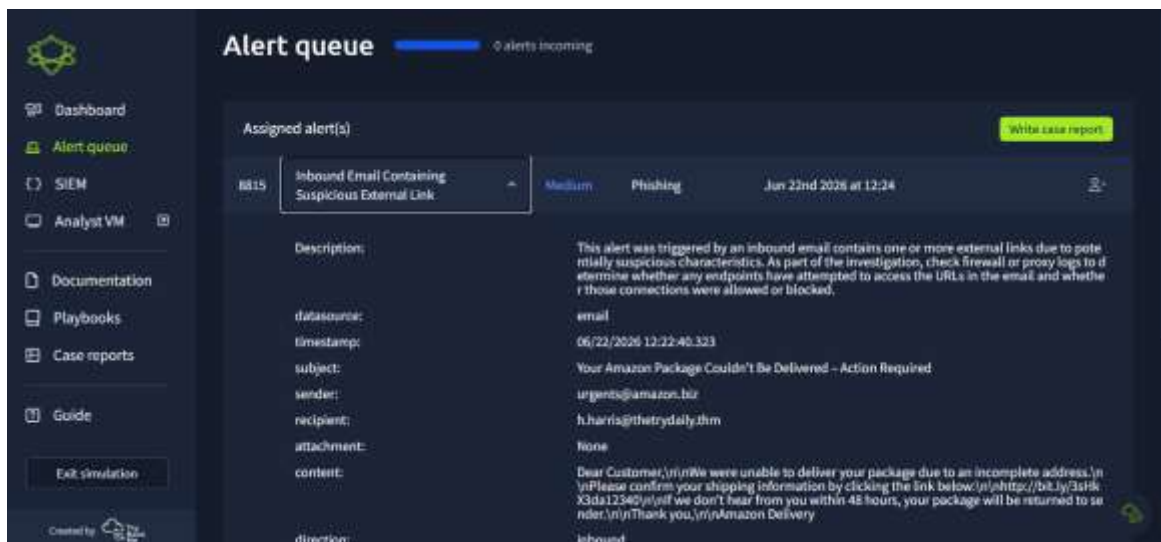


Figure 2 — Alert 8815 detail: phishing email from urgents@amazon.biz to Hannah Harris containing a bit.ly link

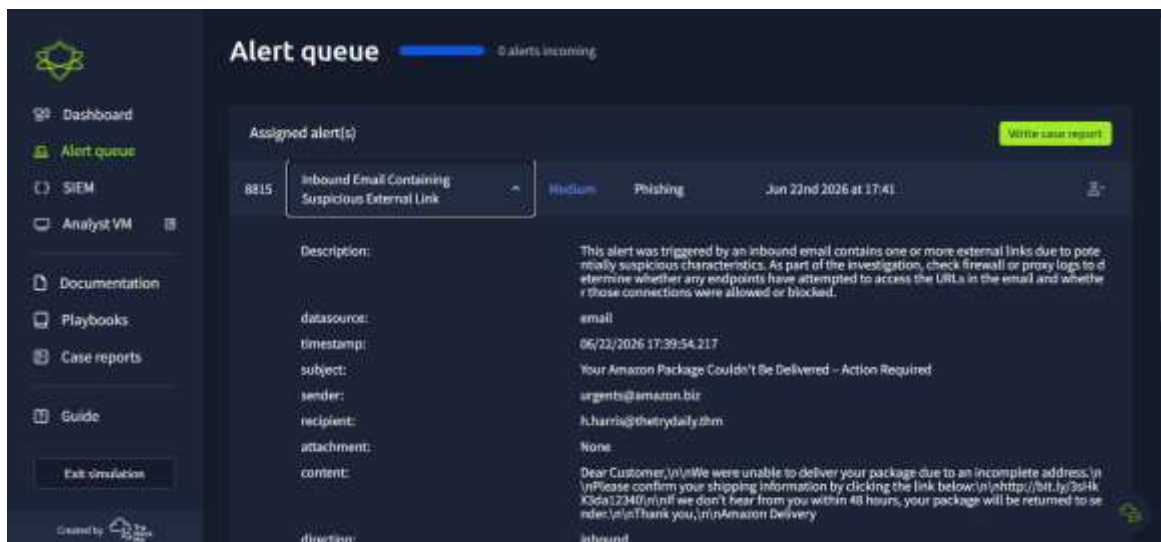


Figure 3 — Same alert as viewed when reassigned later — same sender, same content, same indicators

The alert showed an inbound email sent to Hannah Harris (h.harris@thetrydaily.thm) at 17:39:54 from urgents@amazon.biz. The subject line was 'Your Amazon Package Couldn't Be Delivered – Action Required.' The email body told Hannah to click a link to confirm her shipping information within 48 hours or her package would be returned.

Phishing Indicators Spotted at First Review

1. Sender domain: urgents@amazon.biz — Amazon's real domain is amazon.com. The .biz suffix is a spoofed lookalike domain.
2. Shortened URL: http://bit.ly/3sHkX3da12340 — legitimate companies never use bit.ly in official communications. Shortened URLs are used to hide the real destination.
3. Generic greeting: 'Dear Customer' — real Amazon emails address you by your

account name, not a generic title. 4. Urgency pressure: '48 hours or your package will be returned' — designed to make the recipient act without thinking.

Step 3 — Searching Splunk: Hannah's Email Activity

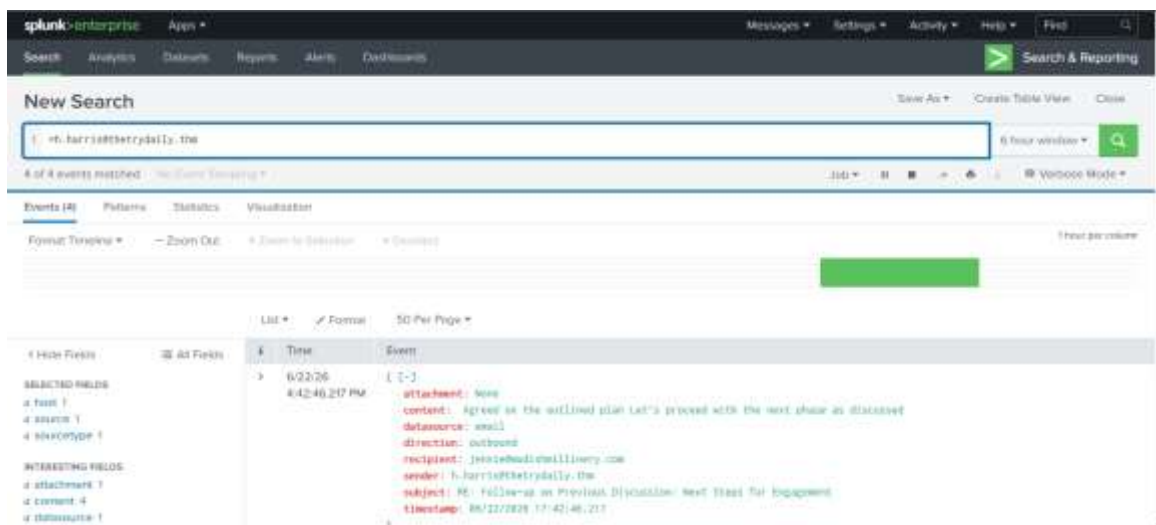


Figure 4 — Splunk search for h.harris@thetrydaily.thm: 4 events returned showing Hannah's email activity around the time of the alert

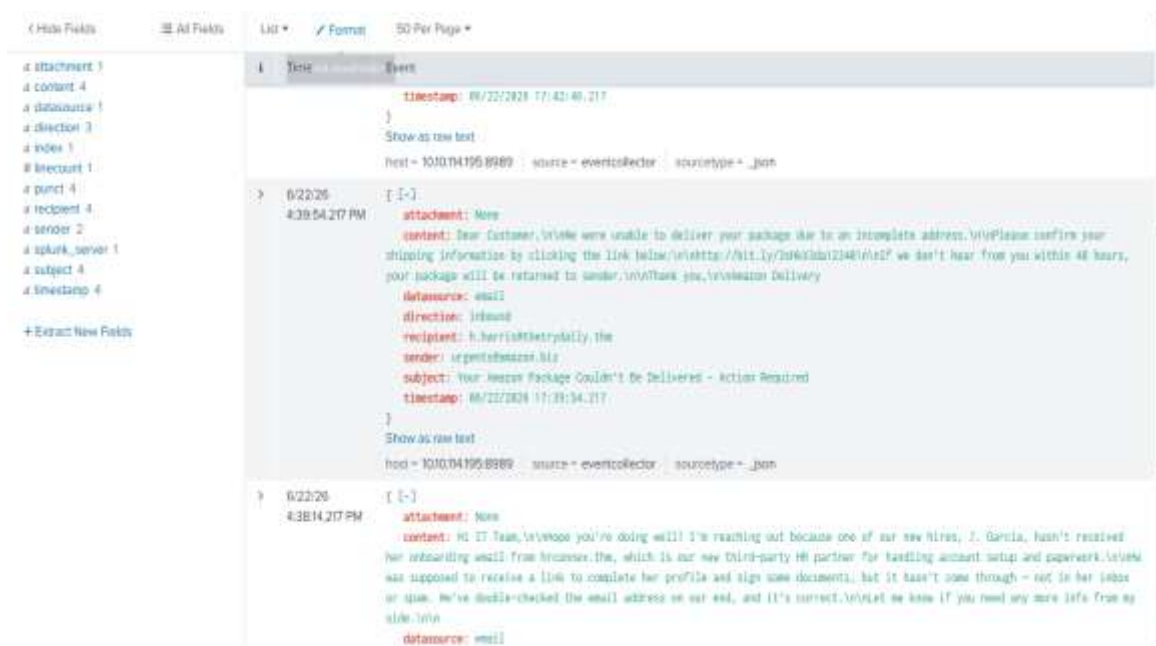


Figure 5 — Events 2 and 3: phishing email received at 17:39, and Hannah's internal email to IT Support at 17:38



Figure 6 — Events 3 and 4: internal email and outbound business email from Hannah — normal work activity

Searching for Hannah's email address returned 4 events. Reading them in order painted a clear picture of her activity around the time of the alert:

- **17:37:15** — Hannah sent an outbound email to le@gmail.com about scheduling a virtual meeting. Normal work activity.
- **17:38:14** — Hannah sent an internal email to Jacob Carter (IT Support) about Julia Garcia's onboarding email from hrconnex.thm not arriving. This was the same IT support thread we saw in Alert 8814.
- **17:39:54** — The phishing email from urgents@amazon.biz arrived in Hannah's inbox. This is the alert email.
- **17:42:46** — Hannah sent an outbound email to jennie@modishmillinery.com about next steps on a business engagement. Normal work activity.

Nothing in her email activity suggested this was a false alarm. The email arrived, and based on the firewall logs I would check next, something happened two minutes later.

Step 4 — Searching Splunk: Hannah's Machine Firewall Traffic

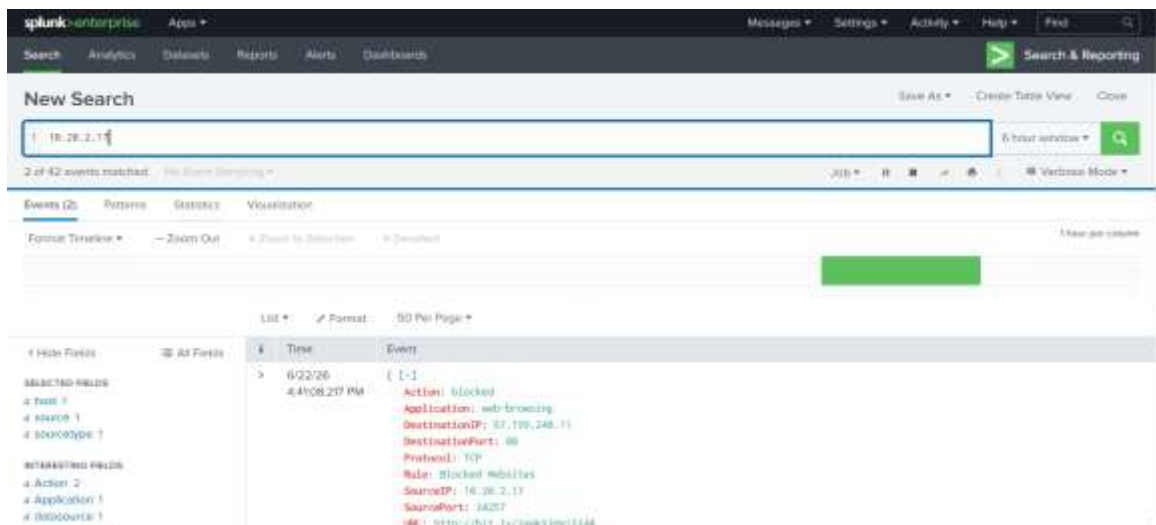


Figure 7 — Splunk search for 10.20.2.17: firewall log shows **BLOCKED** connection to bit.ly from Hannah's machine at 17:41

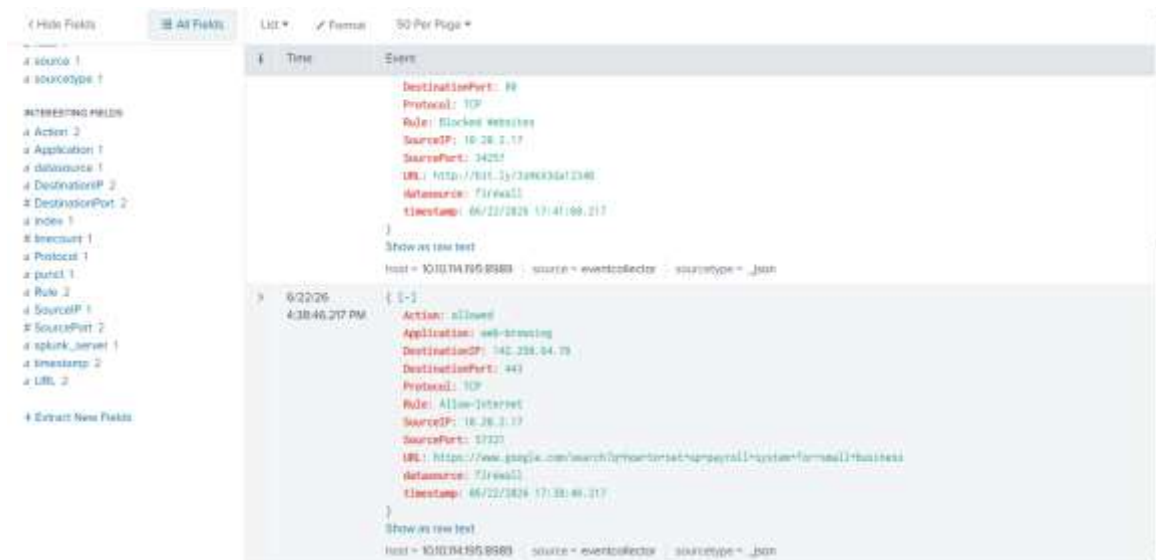


Figure 8 — Full firewall log entries: blocked bit.ly connection and earlier allowed Google search from same machine

Searching for Hannah's IP address (10.20.2.17) in Splunk returned two firewall events:

- **17:38:46** — Hannah's machine connected to Google and searched 'how to set up payroll system for small business.' This was allowed. Normal work browsing.
- **17:41:08** — Hannah's machine attempted to connect to <http://bit.ly/3sHkX3da12340> — the exact URL from the phishing email. The firewall **BLOCKED** this connection under the rule 'Blocked Websites.' Destination IP was 67.199.248.11 on port 80.

Key Finding

Hannah clicked the phishing link at 17:41:08 — exactly 81 seconds after the email arrived at 17:39:54. Her machine sent a connection request to the malicious bit.ly URL, but the company firewall blocked it before the destination was reached. No data was transmitted.

Step 5 — Searching Splunk: Confirming the bit.ly URL

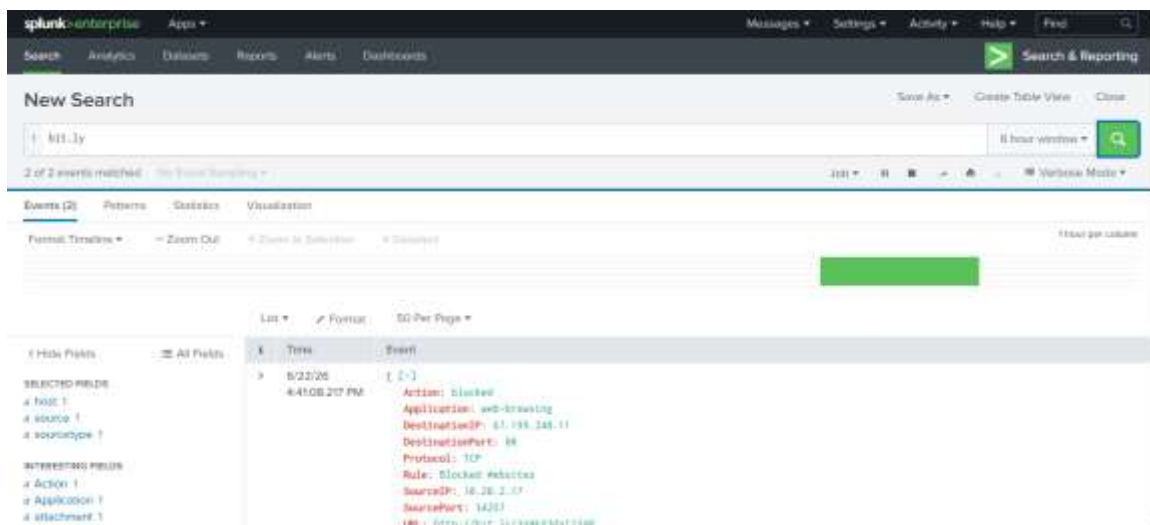


Figure 9 — Splunk search for 'bit.ly': confirms only one event — the blocked connection from Hannah's machine

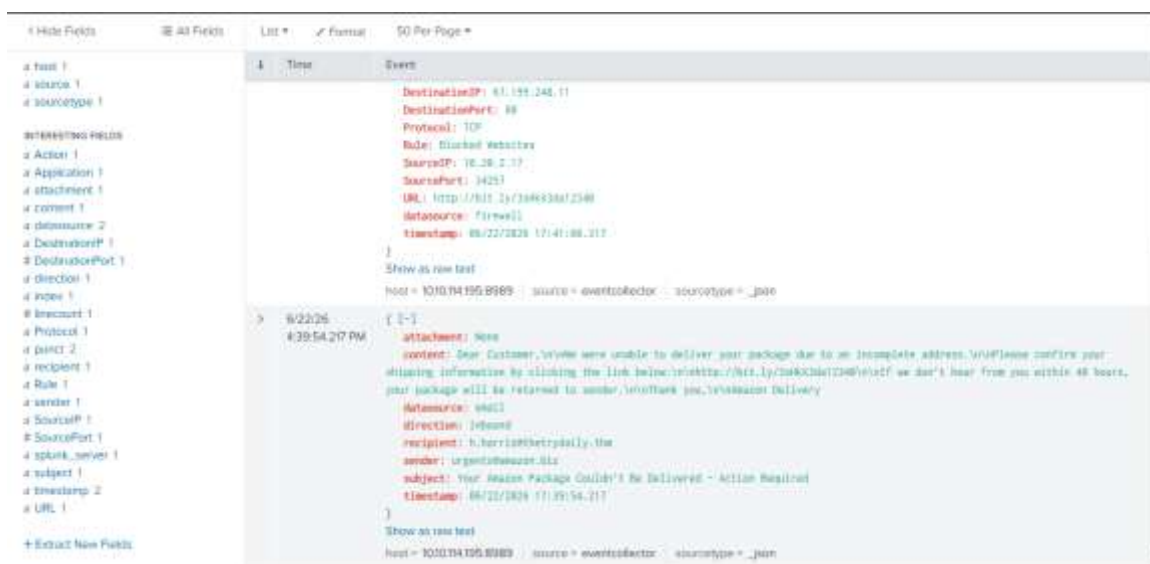


Figure 10 — Full event details for the bit.ly firewall log entry confirming block action and destination IP

Searching directly for 'bit.ly' in Splunk confirmed only one event across the entire environment — the blocked connection from 10.20.2.17. No other machine in the company had attempted to access this URL. The threat was contained to Hannah's endpoint, and even there it was blocked before reaching the destination.

Step 6 — Searching Splunk: The Sender Domain

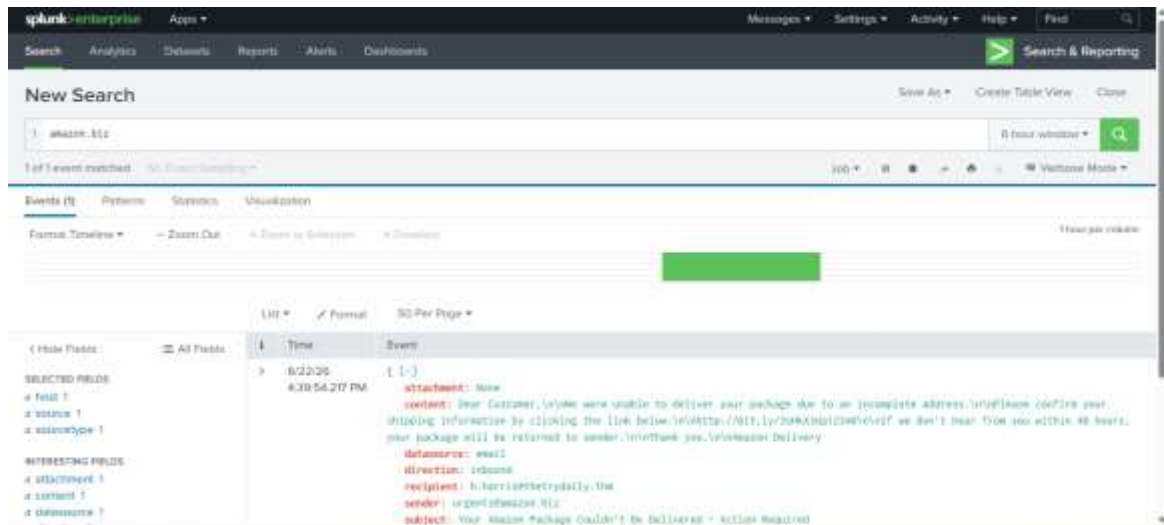


Figure 11 — Splunk search for amazon.biz: one result — the phishing email itself

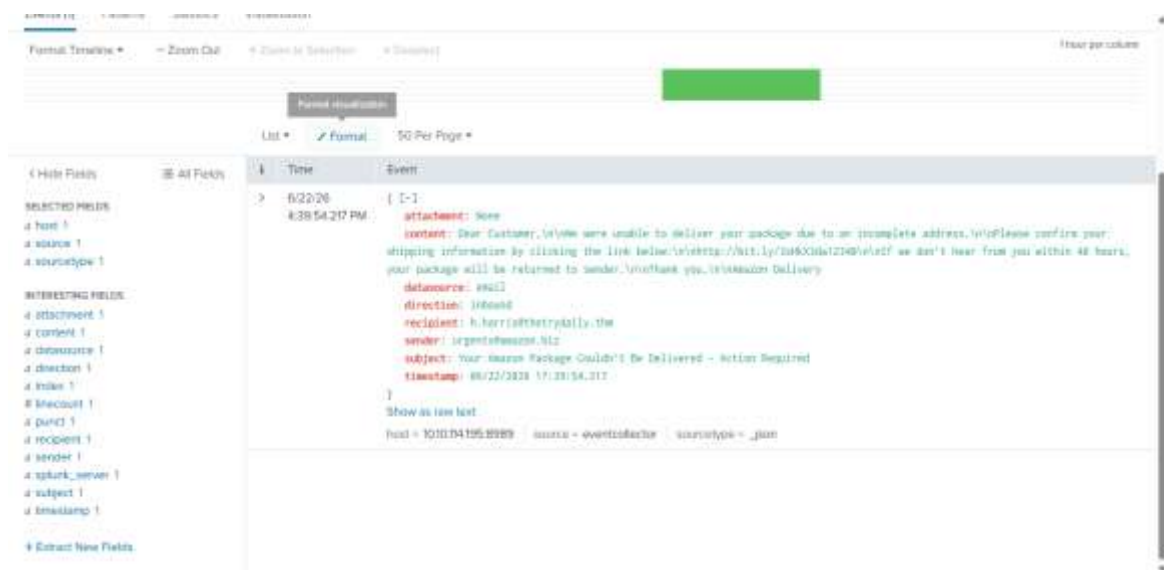


Figure 12 — Full email log for the phishing email from urgents@amazon.biz confirming all details

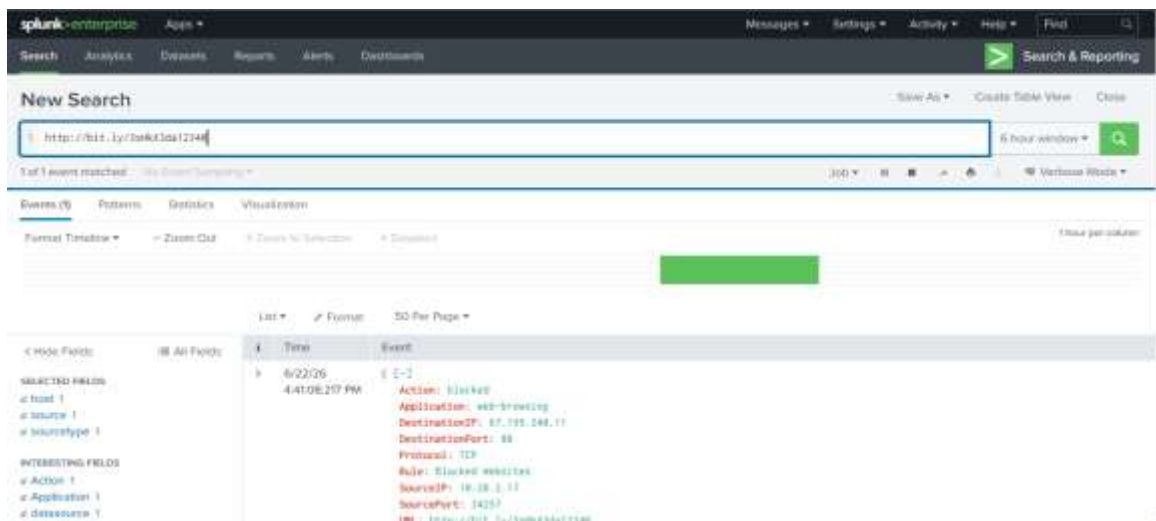


Figure 13 — Splunk search for the full bit.ly URL confirming the firewall block event

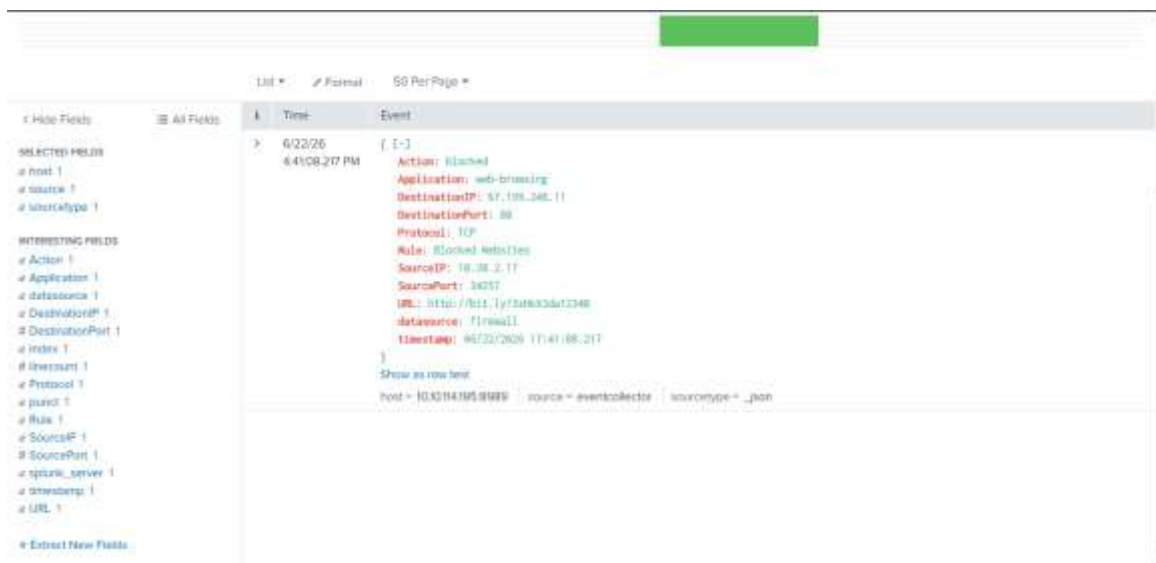


Figure 14 — Full firewall log for the bit.ly connection attempt with all IOCs visible

Searching for 'amazon.biz' returned only one result — the phishing email itself. There was no history of this domain communicating with The Try Daily before. This is not a known vendor or approved sender. Combined with the .biz domain spoofing Amazon's real .com domain, this confirmed the sender was impersonating Amazon.

Step 7 — TryDetectThis: Threat Intelligence Checks

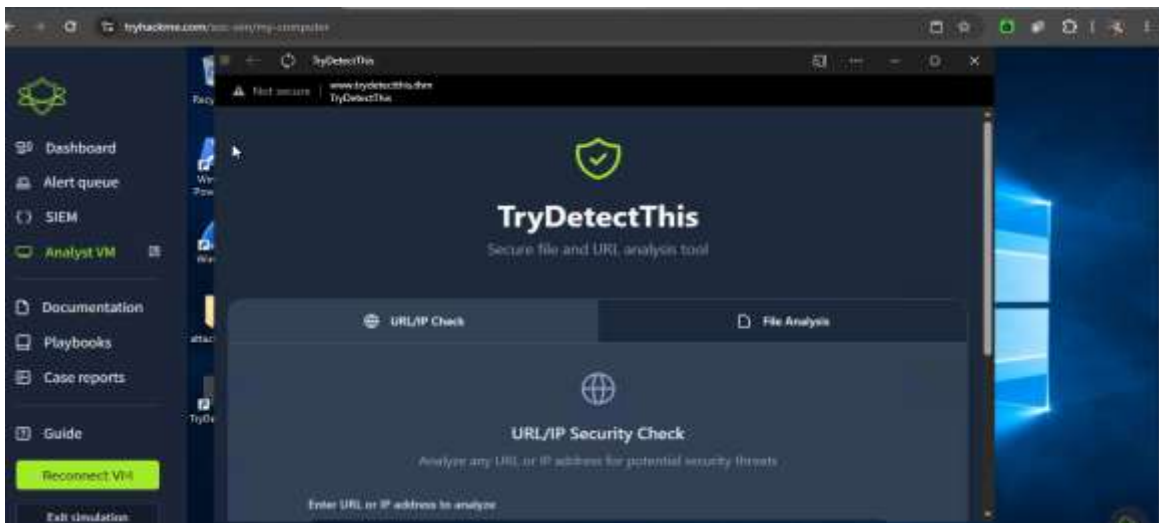


Figure 15 — Analyst VM open with TryDetectThis loaded — URL/IP Security Check tab selected

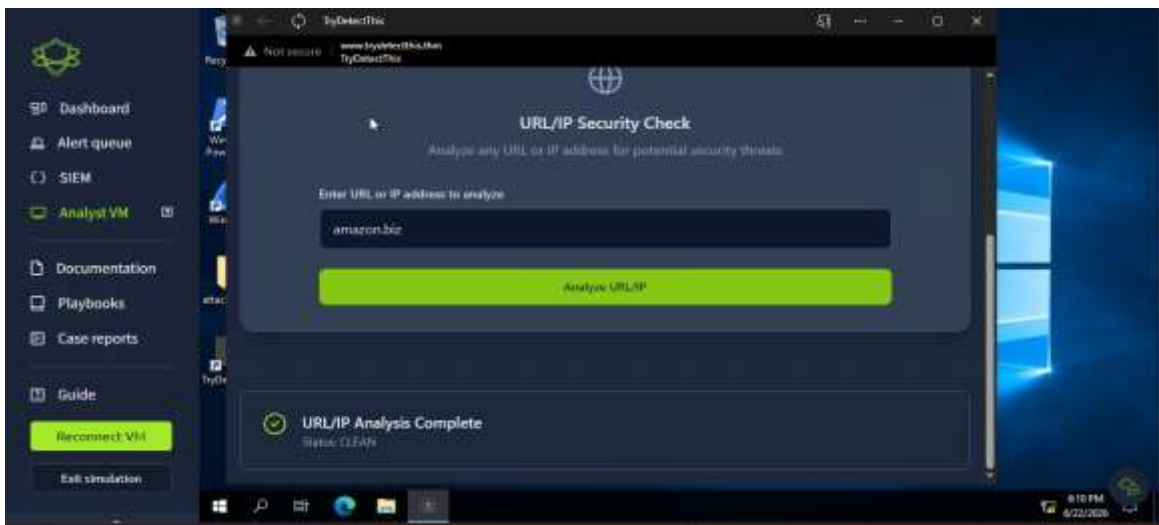


Figure 16 — TryDetectThis result for amazon.biz: Status CLEAN — domain itself not flagged

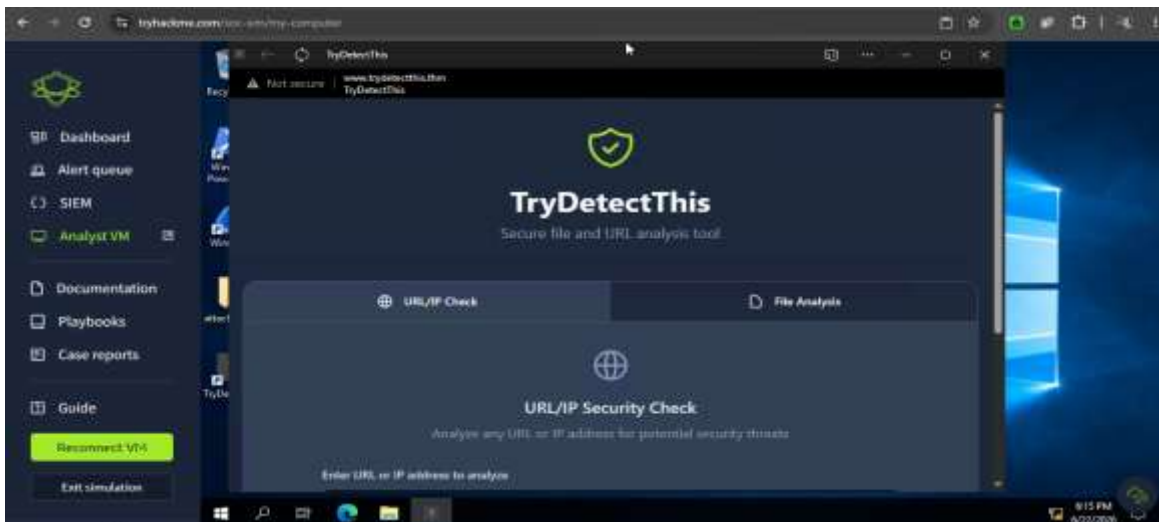


Figure 17 — TryDetectThis ready for the second check — the full bit.ly URL

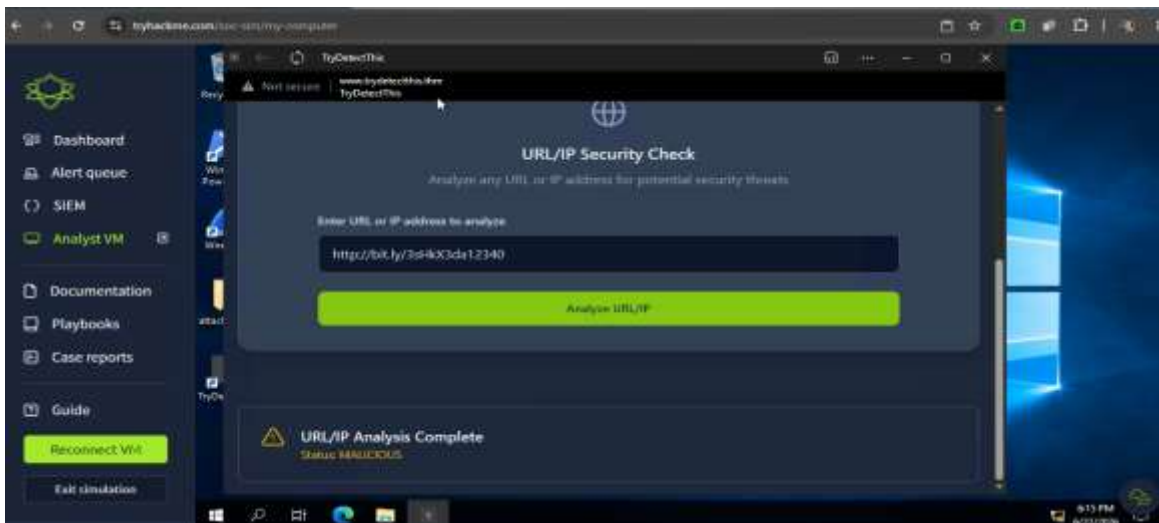


Figure 18 — TryDetectThis result for <http://bit.ly/3sHkX3da12340>: Status MALICIOUS — confirmed threat

I ran two checks on TryDetectThis:

- **amazon.biz** — returned Status: CLEAN. The domain itself is not flagged in threat intelligence. This is common — spoofed domains are often newly registered and not yet blacklisted. However, the fact that it is not amazon.com is still a clear indicator of impersonation.
- **<http://bit.ly/3sHkX3da12340>** — returned Status: MALICIOUS. The actual URL Hannah clicked is confirmed as a known malicious indicator. This sealed the verdict.

Why the Clean Sender Domain Does Not Clear the Alert

A CLEAN result for amazon.biz does not mean the email is legitimate. Threat intelligence tools rate what they have seen before — a freshly registered spoofed domain will often return CLEAN because it has not been reported yet. The real evidence was the malicious bit.ly URL that the email was designed to get Hannah to click.

Step 8 — Writing the Case Report



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SIEM

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Guide

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← Case report for event ID: 8815

ID	Alert rule	Description	Incident type	Severity level	Date and time detected
8815	Inbound Email Containing Suspicious External Link	This alert was triggered by an inbound email contains one or more external links due to potentially suspicious characteristics. As part of the investigation, check firewall or proxy logs to determine whether any endpoints	Phishing	Medium	Jun 22nd 2026 at 17:42



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Incident report

Incident classification

☒ True positive

☐ False positive



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Incident classification

☒ True positive

☐ False positive

Case report

Please write a detailed report on the steps taken to analyze and contain this incident, including all relevant information and the rationale for its closure.

B I U A ↵ ↶ ↷ ↸

Time of activity: 06/22/2026 at 17:39:54

List of Affected Entities:

- Recipient: h.harris@thehydaily1hm
- Sender: urgents@amazon.biz
- Source IP: 10.20.2.17
- Destination IP: 67.199.248.11
- URL: <http://bit.ly/3sHKK3da12340>
- Subject: Your Amazon Package Couldn't Be Delivered - Action Required

Reason for Classifying as True Positive: This alert was triggered by an inbound email containing a suspicious external link. Initial review identified several phishing indicators, including the use of an unofficial sender domain (amazon.biz), urgency based language and a shortened



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analyse and contain this incident, including all relevant information and the rationale for its closure.

URL intended to conceal the destination. Email log analysis confirmed that the message was delivered to h.harris@thetrydaily.thm. Firewall logs showed that the recipient's workstation (10.20.2.17) attempted to access the embedded Bit.ly link shortly after the email was received. Further investigation using Try0DetectThis identified the URL as MALICIOUS. Correlation of firewall and email logs confirmed that the connection attempt was blocked by the organization's web filtering policy before communication with the malicious destination could be established. Based on the available evidence, this alert represents a confirmed phishing attempt targeting an employee and is therefore classified as a True Positive.

Reason for Escalating the Alert: Escalation is not required. Although the user attempted to access the malicious URL, firewall controls successfully blocked the connection before communication with the malicious

Does this alert require escalation?

☐ Yes ☐ No



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analyse and contain this incident, including all relevant information and the rationale for its closure.

Blocked the connection before communication with the malicious destination could be established. No evidence of malware execution, credential theft, additional malicious network activity, persistence mechanisms, or endpoint compromise was identified during the investigation. The threat was successfully contained by existing security controls and no further action is required at this time.

Recommended Remediation Actions:

- Notify Hannah Harris that she received and interacted with a phishing email and provide guidance on identifying similar phishing attempts in the future.
- Verify that no additional connection attempts to the malicious URL or destination IP (67.199.248.11) have occurred from other endpoints within the environment.
- Block the sender domain (amazon.biz) and associated indicators of compromise across email and web security controls.
- Continue monitoring for similar phishing campaigns targeting employees.

Does this alert require escalation?

☐ Yes ☐ No



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analyse and contain this incident, including all relevant information and the rationale for its closure.

- Block the sender domain (amazon.biz) and associated indicators of compromise across email and web security controls.
- Continue monitoring for similar phishing campaigns targeting employees.
- Reinforce phishing awareness training, with emphasis on shortened URLs, delivery themed scams and urgency based social engineering techniques.

List of Attack Indicators: Sender Email:

- urgentb@amazon.biz

Subject Line:

- Your Amazon Package Couldn't Be Delivered - Action Required

Malicious URL:

- <http://bit.ly/3siHx3da12340>

Destination IP:

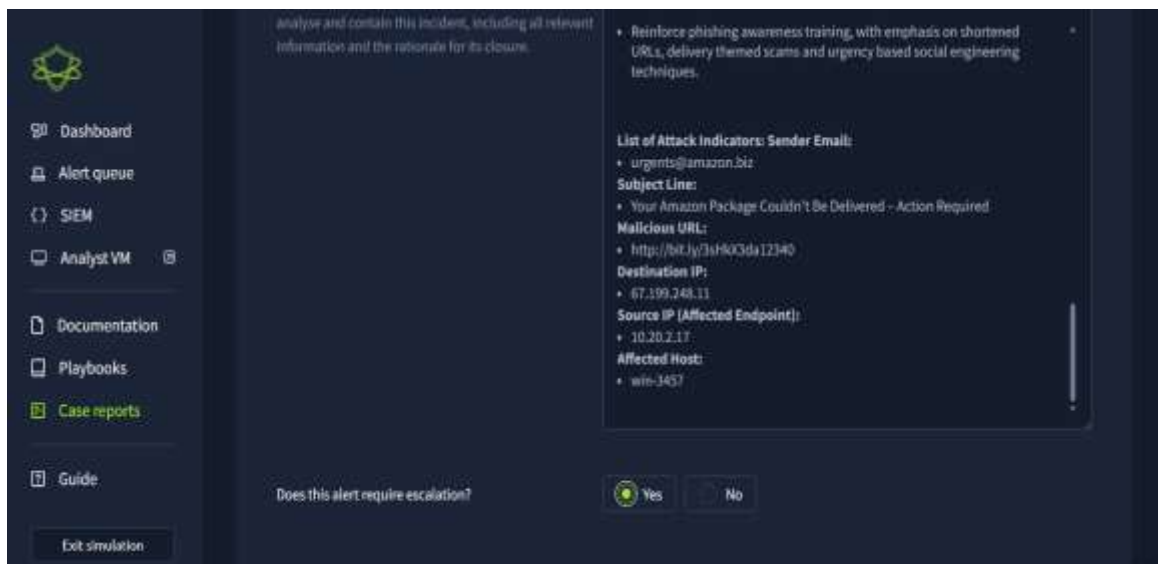
- 67.199.248.11

Source IP (Affected Endpoint):

- 10.20.2.17

Does this alert require escalation?

☐ Yes ☐ No



The case report for Alert 8815 was a True Positive report form — more detailed than the False Positive form used for Alert 8814. It required the following sections, all of which I completed:

- **Time of Activity:** 06/22/2026 at 17:39:54
- **List of Affected Entities:** Hannah Harris, her machine win-3457 (10.20.2.17), the sender urgents@amazon.biz, destination IP 67.199.248.11, and the malicious URL.
- **Reason for Classifying as True Positive:** Full written explanation covering the phishing indicators, Splunk findings, and TryDetectThis confirmation.
- **Reason for Escalating the Alert:** Explained that escalation was not required as the firewall successfully blocked the connection before any impact occurred.
- **Recommended Remediation Actions:** Notify Hannah, verify no other endpoints connected to the malicious URL, block the sender domain and associated indicators, and reinforce phishing awareness training.
- **List of Attack Indicators:** Sender email, subject line, malicious URL, destination IP, source IP, and affected host.

5. Results / Findings

Finding	Detail
Alert Classification	TRUE POSITIVE — A real phishing email was delivered and the recipient clicked the malicious link.

Email Received	Hannah Harris (h.harris@thetrydaily.thm) received a phishing email at 17:39:54 from urgents@amazon.biz impersonating Amazon.
Link Clicked	Firewall logs confirmed Hannah's machine (10.20.2.17) attempted to connect to the malicious bit.ly URL at 17:41:08 — 81 seconds after the email arrived.
Connection Blocked	The firewall blocked the connection under the 'Blocked Websites' rule before the destination (67.199.248.11:80) was reached. No data was transmitted.
Threat Confirmed	TryDetectThis confirmed the URL http://bit.ly/3sHkX3da12340 as MALICIOUS. The sender domain amazon.biz returned CLEAN but is a clear Amazon impersonation.
Escalation Decision	No escalation required. The threat was fully contained by existing firewall controls before any impact to the organisation.
IOCs Identified	Sender: urgents@amazon.biz URL: http://bit.ly/3sHkX3da12340 Dest IP: 67.199.248.11 Source: 10.20.2.17 Host: win-3457

VERDICT: TRUE POSITIVE — No Escalation Required

Alert 8815 was a confirmed phishing attempt. A spoofed Amazon email was delivered to Hannah Harris, who clicked the embedded malicious bit.ly link within 81 seconds. The company's web filtering policy blocked the outbound connection to 67.199.248.11 before any communication with the malicious destination could be established. TryDetectThis confirmed the URL as malicious. No data was exfiltrated, no payload was delivered, and no endpoint was compromised. The threat was fully contained by existing security controls.

6. Skills Demonstrated

- **Phishing Email Analysis** — identified multiple phishing indicators from the alert details before starting any investigation: spoofed sender domain, shortened URL, generic greeting, and urgency-based social engineering.
- **SIEM Log Analysis (Splunk)** — queried email logs and firewall logs across multiple search terms to build a complete timeline of the incident and confirm whether the user interacted with the malicious link.
- **Firewall Log Interpretation** — correctly read and interpreted firewall log entries including action (blocked/allowed), source IP, destination IP, destination port, URL, and the rule that triggered the block.

- **Threat Intelligence (TryDetectThis)** — ran multiple IOC checks, interpreted the results accurately, and understood why a CLEAN result for the sender domain did not clear the alert.
- **IOC Identification and Documentation** — extracted and documented all relevant network and host indicators: sender email, malicious URL, destination IP, source IP, affected hostname, and subject line.
- **Alert Classification** — correctly identified a True Positive based on evidence, and correctly determined that no escalation was required because the threat was blocked before causing impact.
- **Incident Report Writing** — completed a detailed True Positive case report covering all required fields including entities, timeline, classification rationale, escalation reasoning, remediation actions, and attack indicators.
- **Analytical Thinking Under Pressure** — worked against the MTTR timer while making accurate, evidence-based decisions without rushing to a conclusion before the investigation was complete.

7. What I Learned

Alert 8815 taught me something important — the difference between a threat that was stopped and a threat that never existed. These are two very different things, and knowing how to tell them apart matters.

With Alert 8814, the email was legitimate. Nothing bad happened and nothing was ever going to happen. With Alert 8815, something bad absolutely happened — Hannah received a real phishing email and she clicked the link. The only reason this did not become a serious incident is that the firewall caught it in time. That is not the same as a false alarm. That is a near miss, and near misses deserve just as much documentation and follow-up as actual incidents.

A few things I took away from this specifically:

- **A CLEAN result from threat intelligence does not mean something is safe.** The sender domain amazon.biz came back CLEAN because it was likely a newly registered spoofed

domain that had not been reported yet. The real threat was in the URL — and that was MALICIOUS. Always check all the indicators, not just one.

- **The firewall log tells you more than just whether traffic was blocked.** It tells you the exact time, the source machine, the destination, and the rule that fired. Reading those details carefully is what let me confirm Hannah clicked the link and exactly when she did it.
- **Urgency in an email is almost always a red flag.** '48 hours or your package will be returned' is designed to bypass rational thinking. Most real legitimate emails from real companies do not give you a hard deadline that forces you to act immediately without verifying anything.
- **Speed matters — but accuracy matters more.** The simulator tracks MTTR, which means there is pressure to close alerts quickly. But closing an alert incorrectly wastes more time than taking an extra two minutes to verify your findings properly. I learned to move efficiently without cutting corners.
- **Documenting your reasoning is as important as reaching the right verdict.** A good case report shows not just what you decided but why. Anyone reading it — a senior analyst, a manager, or a hiring panel reviewing your portfolio — should be able to follow every step of your thinking from the first alert detail to the final classification.

This investigation reinforced that SOC work is not about catching obvious threats — it is about building the habit of checking everything, even when early signs point in one direction. The alert looked like a phishing attempt from the start, and it was. But I still had to prove it with evidence before closing it. That discipline is what makes an analyst reliable.

End of Case Study — Alert 8815

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Figure 28 — Escalation question visible: 'Does this alert require escalation?' — answered Yes based on further review